A call that involved someone blowing half a dozen times into a telephone could, in principle, have led to 'prompt action at a high level in the United States and Great Britain,' regardless of whether the dead letter drop was used.[15] It would be unduly facetious to suggest there was a risk that heavy breathing on a nuisance phone call might have led to World War Three. Indeed, the problems of relying on a single source of warning intelligence (be it human or other) was understood by British and US intelligence. The British were to be told of Penkovsky's warning (by the CIA Station in London). The Joint Intelligence Committee (whose discussion would be attended by the CIA Station Chief) would then make a judgement call before ministers or military officials were informed. This was in keeping with the JIC's role in Whitehall. US procedures were different and allowed the CIA to pass the raw 'data' directly to its 'consumers', including the President.

The KGB's Second Chief Directorate had kept Oleg Penkovsky under close surveillance for some time but were reluctant to move against a member of the GRU (with high-level connections). They also saw opportunities to monitor his contacts. Nevertheless, on 22 October he was arrested and immediately began helping the KGB with their enquiries (so they believed).[16] At 9.00am on 2 November 1962, however, the DISTANT procedure was activated, with two voiceless telephone calls to the US Embassy.[17] The news was immediately passed to John McCone who briefed the President on 3 November. President Kennedy knew of Penkovsky's espionage (though he did not know him by name). McCone explained that the agency believed he had been compromised.[18] The SIS Head of Station in Moscow, Gordon Cowell, shared that view. According to Peter Hennessy, Cowell too received a phone call, but believing that Penkovsky was lost, took no action, and in contrast to his CIA counterparts, the SIS officer did not report what happened to his[19] superiors.

Why did the KGB activate a procedure that warned the West of imminent Soviet military action, when to do so might have calamitous consequences?[20] It did provide them with an opportunity to identify and arrest the western intelligence officer sent to empty the dead letter drop. One intriguing